

amount of domestic and international bandwidth, and this will allow us to launch several broadband applications this year. The plan is also to expand network by utilising the already-existing network of cable operators.”

### What The Biggies Are Doing

VSNL (now owned by Tata Group) has tied up with Cisco to deploy a Metro Ethernet solution for its Tata Indicom Broadband Services brand that will initially cover eight cities in India. It recently acquired telecom biggie Tyco's global network, and combined with its previous acquisition of Dishnet (a local broadband service provider) and the laying of a submarine cable link between Singapore and Chennai, VSNL has its sights set not only in India, but also the rest of the world. What this means for us is that the era of real broadband is not far. This year is just the catalyst one would expect.

Tata Indicom's biggest rival—Reliance Infocomm—is not sitting idle, and has partially kicked off its services. Says a company spokesperson: “We will launch our broadband services for home users in the first quarter of 2005.”

Last year, Reliance acquired Flag, a company that has one of the biggest fibre optic cable networks in the world. While Reliance's broadband services to corporates at speeds of up to 100 Mbps has already commenced, the home segment with improved speeds is expected to 'go live' early this year.

In an interview to *Digit* (November 2004), Reliance Infocomm chairman Mukesh Ambani said: “We want to change the socio-economic landscape of India. Broadband has the capability to do that. We have already networked 5000 cities in India with 1.2 lakh km of fibre optic cable. We will probably enter the home segment at similar speeds as the corporates.”



### Types of Broadband Technologies

| Broadband Provider      | Wireless                                                   |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Applagic Broadband      | Cable and xDSL (Digital Subscriber Line)                   |
| Bharti BT               | Fiber Optic                                                |
| BSES Telecom            | Copper                                                     |
| BSNL-MTNL               | Cable                                                      |
| Capital Technologies    | ADSL                                                       |
| Dishnet DSL             | ADSL                                                       |
| Hathway Cable & Datacom | Cable                                                      |
| In2Cable                | Ethernet                                                   |
| Reliance                | Wireless                                                   |
| Satyam Infoway          | Leased Lines (Cables and Wireless to be introduced)        |
| Sigma Online            |                                                            |
| Spectranet              | Cable, DSL, IP VPN, Leased lines with connectivity options |
| Touchtel                | DSL, Radio Ethernet                                        |
| Wipro Net               | Copper, Fibre optics, Wireless                             |
| Zeenext                 | Cable                                                      |



### Ask The ISP

- ✓ What broadband technology is being used?
- ✓ What are the installation and monthly access fees?
- ✓ At what speed is it being offered? Is there a limit to the downloads?
- ✓ What hardware/software will be provided?
- ✓ What type of technical assistance is offered and when is it available?
- ✓ What are the terms and conditions of the contract and the acceptable user policy?

Another big player, Bharti Broadband (the parent company of cellular service provider Airtel), has launched Networkthree, which employs a network architecture comprising fibre broadband, satellite broadband and Internet and mobile data/GPRS for its broadband services.

Meanwhile, unlike other broadband providers that use cables to deliver their services, Sify offers dedicated broadband access using a technology called “fixed wireless”. This is done in partnership with cable operators who have special devices called “subscriber-units” attached to their buildings that communicate signals with Sify base stations, and which are transmitted to customers via cables.

### What The Users Want

Most of the demand for pure broadband Internet access comes from urban areas, while most of the demand for broadband in the rural areas is for applications like telemedicine.

While there are many who would avail of broadband services only if the prices are brought down, there are some like Thane (Maharashtra) resident Vijayendra Bhoir. Says he, “Cost is no barrier for me provided the service is good and I can use it for interesting applications.”

Others like Mumbai resident and computer applications student Abhishek Pagare feel cost is the prime issue. “An ideal combination would be maximum bandwidth at minimal prices. But seriously, imagine if broadband prices were comparable to those of dial-up or even cheaper. I guess in the long run, broadband service providers can work out equivalent or cheaper usage plans than dial-ups.”

### What Can Broadband Do?

Broadband, for many, is just fast Internet. In a manner of speaking, that is correct. However, applications like e-commerce, high-speed data transfer, video-conferencing and telemedicine, online gaming, video-on-demand, streaming music, and virtual offices are regular broadband applications.

Broadband, therefore, is not just a concept, it is an economy booster. Mobile phones are another target of broadband applications where news-on-the-move, high speed data transfer and e-mail are now regular. ■

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